

Lewis on people

PHIL UA-78 Metaphysics

Prof. Cian Dorr

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Lewis:

[A person] is a streak through the manifold of space-time, a whole composed of stages located at various times and places.

I think we can attribute the following view to Lewis:

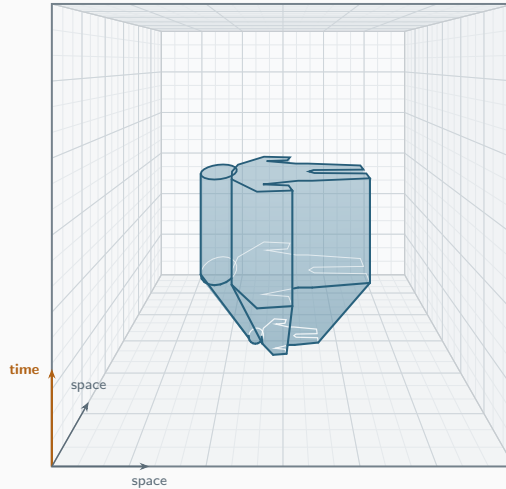
Spatiotemporalism

Every material object is a region of spacetime.

This is sometimes called the view that material objects are *spacetime worms*.

- ▶ We'll follow standard metaphysical usage in counting people as 'objects', although that sounds funny in English.

A 'streak through the manifold of space-time'



Terminology

s is object x 's **stage at** t iff $s = x \cap t$ (and s is nonempty).

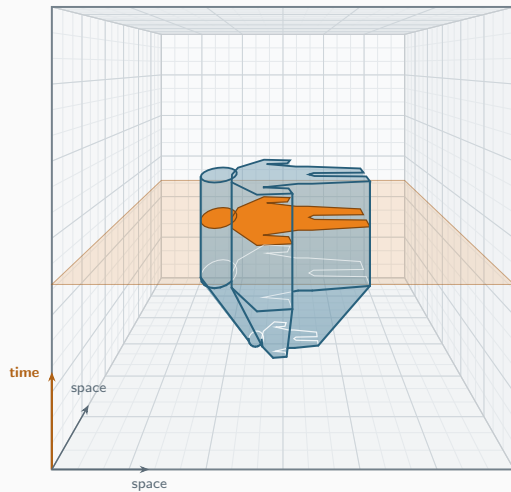
Say that regions x and y **coincide at** t iff $x \cap t = y \cap t$.

- Lewis calls this 'identity-at- t ', but is at pains to emphasize that it is not *numerical identity*.

Given the natural accounts of ordinary geometric predicates, objects that coincide at t will have the same *shape* and *size* at t , and be the same *distance* from everything else at t . Many other 'physical' predicates plausibly work in the same way: e.g., they will have the same *mass* and *charge* at t .

Of course that doesn't mean they stand in *all* the same relations to t ! E.g., one might be 40 years old at t while the other was not.

x' 's stage at t



Identity-at-time- t [i.e., coincidence at t] is an indiscernibility relation for a significant class of properties of continuant persons: those properties that are logically determined by the properties of his stage at t [i.e., intersection with t]. The class includes the properties of walking, being tall, being in a certain room, being thirsty, and believing in God at time t ; but not the properties of being forty-three years old, gaining weight, being an ex-Communist, or remembering one's childhood at t . [Lewis, 'Survival and Identity', section III]

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- I can see why his list includes 'being tall' and 'being in a certain room'; and maybe we can give him 'walking'. But the inclusion of 'being thirsty' and 'believing in God' is controversial! You might think that nothing other than a person could believe in God. Lewis doesn't seem to have any argument against this.

Abundance of coinciding objects

Every object that exists at a time coincides with *enormously many* other objects at that time: just take the *union* ('join') of its intersection with t with any other region that does not intersect t .

Some have found this multiplicity absurd! (See the Korman paper we'll be reading in a couple of weeks.)

But note that we don't have to say that there are lots of coinciding *people* or *tables* or *planets* or anything like that. Ordinary counting judgments normally are expressed using nouns like these.

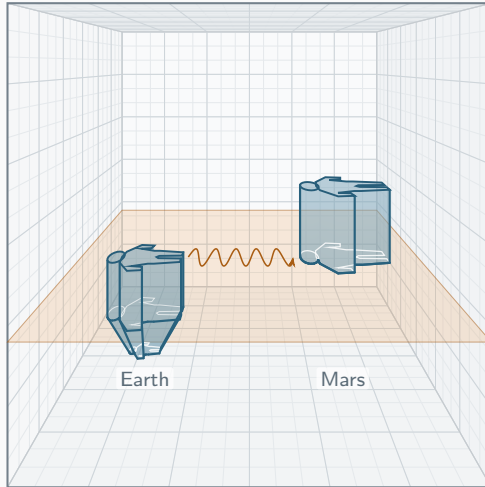
Teletransportation

A famous case

I enter the Teletransporter. I have been to Mars before, but only by the old method, a space-ship journey taking several weeks. This machine will send me at the speed of light. I merely have to press the green button. Like others, I am nervous. Will it work? I remind myself what I have been told to expect. When I press the button, I shall lose consciousness, and then wake up at what seems a moment later. In fact I shall have been unconscious for about an hour. The Scanner here on Earth will destroy my brain and body, while recording the exact states of all of my cells. It will then transmit this information by radio. Travelling at the speed of light, the message will take three minutes to reach the Replicator on Mars. This will then create, out of new matter, a brain and body exactly like mine. It will be in this body that I shall wake up. Though I believe that this is what will happen, I still hesitate.

But then I remember seeing my wife grin when, at breakfast today, I revealed my nervousness. As she reminded me, she has been often teletransported, and there is nothing wrong with her. I press the button. (Parfit, *Reasons and Persons*.)

Teletransportation



The question

Here are some questions I might ask about this case:

- ▶ If I press the button, will I still *exist* afterwards?
- ▶ If I press the button, will I still be a *person* afterwards?
- ▶ *Should* I press the button (given the things I care about)? Is there any *reason* to prefer, e.g., a long and inconvenient trip to Mars by spaceship?

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Parfit's view: You won't exist afterwards. (See below for his argument for this.) But this is no big deal, and there's no reason to care. We get *what matters in survival*, even though we don't literally survive.

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Yes on all three counts! The characters in the story are right—teletransportation is a way of moving a person from one place to another.

The key thing to bear in mind is that given spatiotemporalism, there *is* an object that survives the teletransportation, and an object that doesn't. The question we need to ask is, which of these is a *person*?

This is not a question about the *word* 'person'; but we can still try to answer it by considering how we would apply the word (and related words, including the personal pronouns).

A thought experiment: two cultures

We can imagine two isolated cultures where they have the teletransportation technology. In Culture A they say things like ‘This is a convenient way of moving a person to a new place’. In Culture B they instead say ‘This is a way of destroying a person and making a new one just like them’.

Suppose that in Culture A teletransportation is widely used and people think nothing of it, while in Culture B, people are very unwilling to use the technology—the only people who do it are people *in extremis* (e.g. terminally ill).

A thought experiment: two cultures

Lewis would surely say that the word 'person' in the language of Culture A applies to things that *do* survive teletransportation, while in the language of Culture B, it applies to things that do *not*. Similarly for their proper names, personal pronouns, etc.

- And maybe also words like 'dog', 'jacket', etc., if they say things like 'I brought my dog with me on my trip to Mars by teletransporter'.

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NB this is NOT the claim that *people in Culture A* survive and *people in Culture B* do not. *That* weird claim is made using *our* word 'person', not theirs.

Lewis thinks that *English* is like the language of Culture A: 'person' in *English* applies to objects that *do* survive processes like teletransportation that secure 'mental continuity and connectedness'. This is based on how he thinks we are disposed to describe and feel about such processes.

Fission

Parfit's argument that we don't survive teletransportation

What if, instead of destroying the original matter, we 'upgrade' the device so that it keeps that matter around?

Parfit's judgment: in *that* case, no-one moves to Mars: one person stays on Earth, and another is created on Mars.

And it makes no difference if the one on Earth is destroyed soon after. But it seems absurd to think that it makes a huge difference whether the destruction is delayed for a few seconds.

If the original is not destroyed

